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"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, mostly sunny, cooler, high 64. **Tonight,** cloudy, rain late, low 56. **Tomorrow,** light rain early, then an afternoon shower and thunderstorm, high 72. Weather map, Page A24.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,038 © 2026 The New York Times Company THURSDAY, OCTOBER 15, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00







PHOTOGRAPHS BY HANNAH BEIER FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Producers of the most popular fruit in the U.S. face rising costs of fuel, fertilizer and other materials. "It is a crisis," one executive said.

Rising Energy Costs Push Inflation at a Rapid Pace

Wage Growth Muted, Complicating Effort by Trump to Sell Voters on Economy

By COLBY SMITH

Higher energy prices drove up inflation in the United States in September, a warning shot to President Trump ahead of midterm elections that have centered primarily on affordability concerns. The uptick in consumer prices will also keep the Federal Reserve under pressure to raise interest rates for a second time this year.

The Consumer Price Index Report, released by the Bureau of Labor Statistics on Wednesday, showed that overall prices rose 0.6 percent, the largest monthly increase in five months. Compared with the same time last year, prices were 3.7 percent higher.

The bulk of the increase stemmed directly from energy prices, which have shot higher this year because of the war with Iran. That has translated into increased costs for Americans, who are paying more to fill their cars, heat their homes and travel by air.

Gasoline prices, which in late September rose to nearly $4.50 a gallon, surged 9.1 percent for the month. That accounted for more than half of the overall monthly increase in prices. Gas prices are up 34.2 percent over the past year.

Fuel oil prices, used for heating in many homes in the Northeast, have also shot higher, rising 15.3 percent in September, or 74.2 percent on an annual basis. Higher fuel costs have boosted airfares, which were up 1.2 percent in September, or 22.4 percent over the year.

Food prices were flat for the month, but over the past 12 months have risen 2.5 percent.

"Core" inflation, which excludes volatile energy and food prices, edged higher as well, but by a smaller magnitude. Over the course of September, these prices were up only 0.3 percent. Over the past year, they were up 2.6 percent.

The data comes at a highly sensitive political moment, with the midterm elections just weeks away and Republicans under pressure to retain their control of Congress. Several traditionally safe Republican seats are now in play for Democrats, who have continued to blame Mr. Trump for higher prices.

Mr. Trump has often sought to dismiss the notion that the affordability crisis has worsened under his watch. At a rally in Alaska late on Tuesday, he proclaimed that prices had improved under his watch.

But September's data suggests a far bleaker backdrop.

Wage growth has remained relatively muted over the past year. That, combined with higher inflation, means Americans are earning less for an hour of work. Average hourly earnings, adjusted for inflation, fell 0.5 percent in September, and were down 0.7 percent from a year earlier. It was the sixth straight month of year-over-year declines in real earnings.

Average hourly earnings are now back to almost where they were when Mr. Trump was sworn into office for the second time in

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For Pope, a New World of Lung Cancer Therapy

Death Rate Has Been Reduced by a Half Since the 1990s

By GINA KOLATA and CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

In a way, Pope Leo XIV may be lucky he got lung cancer now and not, say, six years ago. Treatments have changed so much, specialists say, that the old days are almost unrecognizable.

For many patients, said Karen Knudsen, the chief executive of the Parker Institute in San Francisco, lung cancer is no longer the dire diagnosis it was in the past.

Dr. Lecia Sequist, a thoracic oncologist at Mass General Brigham Cancer Institute, said, "I think a lot of people have that gut reaction about lung cancer — that it can be rapidly fatal — but that is a little bit outdated, especially if it's caught early."

She added, "It's really just a whole new paradigm in lung cancer, and patients are living much longer and cure rates are higher than they were 10 to 20 years ago."

Lung cancer is still the leading cause of cancer deaths for both men and women, killing more than 124,000 Americans each year. But the death rate today is half what it was in the 1990s, partly because fewer people smoke but also because newly developed treatments are working.

Pope Leo's cancer, an adenocarcinoma, was discovered during a routine medical test. The pope's doctors removed a lobe of his lung on Tuesday and are conducting tests to determine what additional treatments, if any, are warranted.

But, said Dr. Robert Merritt, a thoracic surgeon at the Ohio State University Wexner Medical Center, "the fact that the pope was offered surgery as a primary treatment is an indication the tumor is most likely early stage, was detected early and was completely removable with surgery." That means, he added, that "in most cases there's a reasonable chance there could be complete cure."

Still, the pope's doctors almost certainly will do genetic tests of

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Even Bananas Absorb Blows Of War in Iran

By ANA SWANSON

The war in Iran has rippled through the global economy in many ways, pushing up prices for oil, fertilizer and other products. It has also created challenges for America's most popular fruit: bananas.

The banana business has long been an underappreciated feat of logistics. It involves transporting fragile and finicky fruits thousands of miles from the tropics, only to sell them for less than a quarter each. And it's a business that is even trickier of late as the war raises the costs of fuel and other materials banana producers need.

That has put even more financial pressure on banana producers, who operate with thin margins and have little ability to raise prices. Compounding the industry's problems are the threats of disease, climate change, tariffs and an exceptionally severe El Niño this year.

The banana might be America's most unassuming fruit, a cheaply priced staple of smoothies and school cafeterias. It is the most consumed fruit in the United States, with Americans eating around 80 bananas a year, on average.

But bananas make little profit for grocery stores or the companies growing them. Instead, stores price them cheaply to draw shoppers in the door. The average price of bananas in the United States — about 65 cents a pound in August — has changed little over the last decade, despite rising costs.

"Everything is costing more money," said Danny Dumas, a senior vice president at Del Monte North America. "If you ask me, it is a crisis."

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Satellite Cut Hobbles Ukraine As Russia Pounds Power Grid

By CONSTANT MÉHEUT

KYIV, Ukraine — Nearly five years into its fight for national survival, Ukraine has entered a moment of intense vulnerability, under growing pressure not only from Russia but also now from the United States.

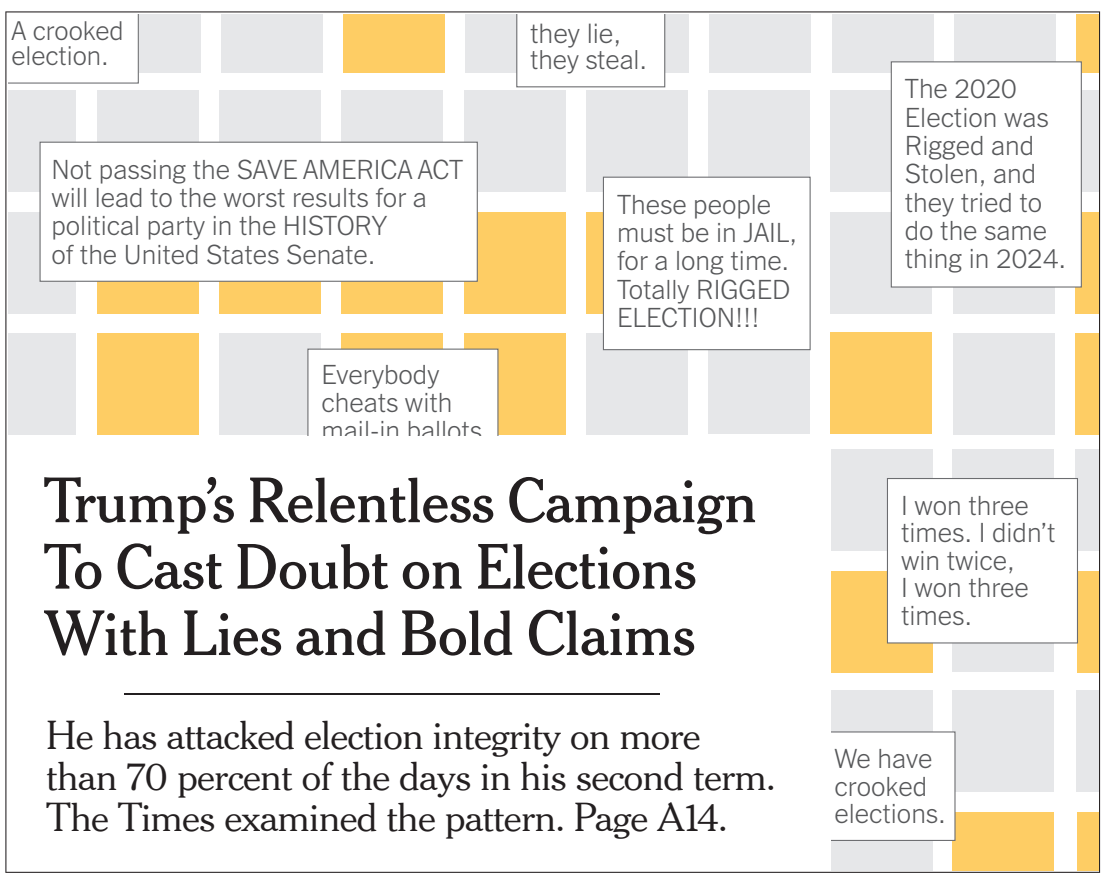
A double blow came overnight into Wednesday.

Ukraine said that its military, with no warning, had lost some critical access to a military version of Starlink, a pillar of its battlefield communications. Kyiv relies on the satellite internet network, Starshield, which is paid for by the Pentagon. That led Ukrainian officials and analysts to surmise that the restrictions had come from Washington, as President Trump is locked in his latest feud with Ukraine's leadership.

At the same time, Russia unleashed dozens of ballistic missiles in a broad attack on Ukraine's energy infrastructure early Wednesday, cutting power to 600,000 people in the capital, Kyiv. It was a dark omen for a rapidly approaching winter in which Russia is gearing up to try to push Ukraine to the breaking point as Kyiv runs low on lifesaving air defenses.

It was unclear how long the Starshield restrictions would remain in place. Still, the Trump administration's treatment of Ukraine has caused outrage in a

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Trump's Relentless Campaign To Cast Doubt on Elections With Lies and Bold Claims

He has attacked election integrity on more than 70 percent of the days in his second term. The Times examined the pattern. Page A14.



JOHANNA-MARIA FRITZ FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

'What Russia Did to My Family'

Yevhen Ovcharov lost his wife and a daughter to a bomb. He is using the tragedy to plead Ukraine's case to the world. Page A6.

Becerra Could Make California History. He's Not Dwelling on It.

Favored as First Latino Governor Since 1875

This article is by ***Laurel Rosenhall****,* ***Jennifer Medina*** *and* ***Orlando Mayorquín****.*

LOS ANGELES — The table decorations at a Los Angeles event earlier this year told the story of the guest of honor, Xavier Becerra, a son of Mexican immigrants who has emerged as the front-runner to replace Gov. Gavin Newsom of California.

Colorful cards in the style of a Mexican lotería game represented his political rise, in Spanish, from El Congresista to El Fiscal General to El Secretario de Salud. The final card, El Gobernador, captured the hope of many of the Hispanic leaders at the event that Mr. Becerra would become California's first Latino governor since 1875.

Those leaders have been more animated about the potential milestone than the candidate himself has been.

"I certainly am Latino, and I'm certainly proud of it," Mr. Becerra said in an interview. "But identity has never been what has fueled my campaigns for office or public service."

Mr. Becerra, a Democrat, is an overwhelming favorite to defeat Steve Hilton, a Republican endorsed by President Trump, in November in this heavily Democratic state.

If Mr. Becerra wins, it would be a watershed moment in California, coming 32 years after Gov. Pete Wilson, a Republican, targeted illegal immigrants during his re-election campaign in 1994.

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Dressing Up for Halloween
We have costume ideas for couples, groups and anyone who wants to be disguised as a famous sheep. PAGE D4

Seeking Best of the Litter
A winemaker is trying to breed a beloved working dog back into prominence. Below, fox collie pups. PAGE D6



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Milei's Dog Psychic
Argentina's president, a devotee of English mastiffs, formerly used an animal communicator. Now, his sister fulfills the role. Global Profile. PAGE A4

Russell Brand on Trial
A British prosecutor said the former film star, who is accused of attacking six women, was a "sexual predator." Mr. Brand has denied all charges. PAGE A10

U.S. Troops to Latin America
The Pentagon is expanding its fight against drug traffickers, even as the plans recall a long and bloody history of U.S. intervention in the region. PAGE A9

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Bill Would Ban Carriages
Under legislation backed by the City Council speaker and the mayor, the use of horse-drawn carriages in Central Park would end by June 2028. PAGE A24

G.O.P. Wary in Great Plains
Republicans have dominated the center of the country for decades. Now they face several tough races. PAGE A13

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Rays Go Back to Basics
Tampa Bay's style of bold base running, solid pitching and stingy fielding evened the A.L.C.S. at one game each. PAGE B8

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Charms of a Rock Frontman
A film and live album explore the irreverent and divisive qualities of the singer-songwriter Cameron Winter. PAGE C1

From Pirouettes to a Tiara
Regan Hutsell, the new Miss America, says dance taught her how to be adaptable without altering who she is. PAGE C1



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Social Security Benefits to Rise
The agency announced a 3.6 percent annual cost-of-living adjustment for 2027, the largest since 2023. PAGE B1

Questioning Hearing for Cook
Critics fear President Trump's handpicked panel will not give the Fed governor, Lisa D. Cook, a fair chance. PAGE B1

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Phil Klay PAGE A23